WORDTRACKER®
KEYWORDS

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Keyword Basics

Start finding the keywords you need to succeed online

How Search Engines Work

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"Why can't my site be found on Google?"

One of the most frequently asked questions we get from website owners is, "Why can't my site be found on Google?" They know it's important to appear at the top of search engine results but they just don't know why it doesn't happen to them.

They may well be in awe of the 'black arts' of search engine optimization or puzzled by the complexity of it all. If they're unlucky they will have paid out money to some snake oil salesman guaranteeing to get them to the top in 48 hours - and been sorely disappointed with the lack of traffic that results.

Most search engine optimizers are highly ethical, professional people but unsurprisingly they tend to keep their cards close to their chest. So what is the website owner to do to compete?

The big secret is there is no big secret

It's true: the 'big secret' of search engine optimization is that there is no big secret.

It is all about understanding what is going on, followed by the hard work and attention to detail that are common to many business activities.

This lesson is about understanding the basics of what is going on inside a search engine. It is just under 800 words in length but that is more than enough to give you what you need to know, to give you what you need to know to get started.

Inside the guts of a search engine

For simplicity's sake, let's say there are three pieces of software that together make up a search engine - the Spider software, the Index software and the Query software.

If you understand what these three do, then you have the foundation for getting your website to the top of the search engines.

Here's what the three types of software do:

The Spider software 'crawls the web looking for new pages to collect and add to the search engine indices'.

This is a metaphor. In reality, the spider doesn't do any 'crawling' and doesn't 'visit' any web pages. It requests pages from a website in the same way as Microsoft Explorer, or Firefox or whatever browser you use requests pages to display on your screen.

The difference is that the spider doesn't collect images or fancy designs - it is only interested in text and links AND the URL, (for example, http://www.Unique-Resource-Locator.html) from which they come: it doesn't display anything and it gets as much information as it can in the shortest time possible.

A spider loves links because they lead it to other web pages that have the things that it loves, guess what? more text, links and URLs!

The Index software catches everything the Spider can throw at it (yes, that's another metaphor). The index makes sense of the mass of text, links and URLs using what is called an algorithm - a complex mathematical formula that indexes the words, the pairs of words and so on.

Essentially, an algorithm analyses the pages and links for word combinations and assigns scores that allow the search engine to judge how important the page (and URL) might be to the person that is searching. And of course it stores all of this information and makes it available to people who are searching.

The Query software is what you see when you use a search engine - it is the front end that everybody thinks of as a search engine. It may look simple but it presents the results of all the remarkable search engine software that works away invisibly on our behalf.

The main feature of the query software is the box into which people type their search terms.

Type in your words, hit search and the search engine will try to match your words with the best web pages in can find through searching the web.

But this too is a metaphor and perhaps the most important one.

The query software doesn't search the web - it checks the records that have been created by its own index software. And those records have been made possible by the raw material the spider software collects.

What you need to understand about search engines

What you need to understand is that the search engine has done all the hard work of collecting and analysing web pages, BUT it only makes that information available when someone does a search by entering words in the search box and hitting return.

The words people use when they search therefore determine the results the search engine presents. We call them keywords - that might sound fancy but keywords are only 'the words people use when they search'.

And keywords are what Wordtracker provides - many millions of them. Use keywords in your website copy and you will prosper: ignore them and your online business will surely perish.

Discovering The Keyword Matrix

chocolate →	truffles	cocoa	fudge
hot chocolate	truffles	cocoa	fudge
chocolate chip cookies	chocolate truffles	cocoa beach	fudge recipes
charlie and the chocolate factory	truffle	hot cocoa	peanut butter fudge
chocolate and dessert recipes	chocolate truffle recipe	cocoa beach florida	fudge recipe
chocolate chip cookie recipe	truffle recipes	hot cocoa mix recipe	peanut butter fudge reci
lg chocolate	chocolate truffle recipes	cocoa beans	pumpkin fudge
chocolate cake	truffle recipe	cocoa puffs	easy fudge recipes
chocolate phone	oreo truffles	cocoa butter	chocolate fudge
chocolate labrador	truffle oil	cocoa tea	church of fudge
chocolate fountain	truffle shuffle	cocoa bean	vanilla fudge
chocolate labs	white truffles	hot cocoa mix	best fudge recipes
chocolate booty	black truffles	hot cocoa recipe	peanut butter fudge reci
chocolate wedding favors	easy truffle recipes	cocoa tree	fantasy fudge
history of chocolate	chocolate truffles recipe	cocoa powder	chocolate fudge recipe
↓ more	↓ more	↓ more	↓ more

But if you want to succeed online, you've got to spend enough time and energy discovering the words your customers really use when they search.

The secret of writing great online copy is simple: use keywords - the words people use when they search - in your copy.

The reasons for this are two fold:

1. If you use the words people use when they search in your copy, page titles, descriptions and links, then you'll score well in search engine results and more people will find your site.

2. The language you use will be appropriate to your audience. And as any seasoned direct marketer will tell you, speak to people in their own language and they will be more likely to buy from you.

That of course begs the question, "How do you find your best keywords"?

Most people either just guess or do perfunctory research using one of the many free keyword tools that are found online.

But if you want to succeed online, you've got to spend enough time and energy discovering the words your customers really use when they search.

You'll need not just 20-30 keywords, you'll need hundreds - and many of the most successful online companies will have thousands of keywords.

The keyword matrix is a simple methodology that allows you to build a comprehensive keyword list using the Wordtracker database. (The Excel spreadsheets we generated for this example were attached to this lesson's email - this gives you almost 5,000 relevant keywords using the full version of Wordtracker and 85 relevant keywords using the free trial version.)

Here are the 3 steps involved:

Step 1 - Start with a common word or phrase that is appropriate to your business

Start simple. Your starting point does not need to be clever or creative. All you need is a common word or phrase relevant to your business - Wordtracker will help you find clever keywords later.

So if I was researching for the market for chocolate, a good starting point would be the word 'chocolate'.

Using the Keyword Researcher at Wordtracker, you can find 1000 keywords that all contain the word, 'chocolate'.

Excellent. So far, so good. Now all you have to do is rush off and optimize your web pages for those phrases, right?

Wrong! That is what most people will do and as a result they will miss out on some very powerful keywords which aren't immediately obvious.

Time to move on to step 2 and get inside the keyword matrix.

Step 2 - Find words that are related to your original keyword

Here the task is not to find relevant keywords that contain the word 'chocolate': in fact, it is just the opposite - to find relevant keywords that do NOT contain the word 'chocolate'.

Go to the Keyword Universe - related keywords feature on Wordtracker and enter the word chocolate. Wordtracker now searches 100 websites that score well on search engines for the search 'chocolate' and extracts the phrases that those sites use. From that you'll find relevant keywords such as truffles, cocoa, fudge, confectionery, gifts, gourmet and so on.

Scan the list of related keywords and pick the ones that YOU feel are relevant to your business. Your input is required: Wordtracker is not a machine that churns out a list of keywords that will automatically bring you a fortune. If it was, everybody would get the same results. Rather, Wordtracker is a tool that allows you to find your best keywords.

So from the list of related terms you might pick truffles, cocoa, fudge and candy.

Step 3 - Use the related words to generate many more relevant keywords

Essentially, this repeats step 1 for each of the related keywords that you have chosen. Take each of your chosen related words and enter them into the Keyword Researcher tool in turn.

chocolate →	truffles	cocoa	fudge	candy → more
hot chocolate	truffles			
chocolate chip cookies	chocolate truffles			
charlie and the chocolate factory	truffle			
chocolate and dessert recipes	chocolate truffle recipe			
chocolate chip cookie recipe	truffle recipes			
lg chocolate	chocolate truffle recipes			
chocolate cake	truffle recipe			
chocolate phone	oreo truffles			
chocolate labrador	truffle oil			
chocolate fountain	truffle shuffle			
chocolate labs	white truffles			
chocolate booty	black truffles			
chocolate wedding favors	easy truffle recipes			
history of chocolate	chocolate truffles recipe			
↓ more	↓ more			

By following this methodology, you can quickly generate hundreds of relevant keywords that reflect the subtleties – and niche markets – within your marketplace.

chocolate →	truffles	cocoa	fudge	candy → more
hot chocolate	truffles	cocoa		
chocolate chip cookies	chocolate truffles	cocoa beach		
charlie and the chocolate factory	truffle	hot cocoa		
chocolate and dessert recipes	chocolate truffle recipe	cocoa beach florida		
chocolate chip cookie recipe	truffle recipes	hot cocoa mix recipe		
lg chocolate	chocolate truffle recipes	cocoa beans		
chocolate cake	truffle recipe	cocoa puffs		
chocolate phone	oreo truffles	cocoa butter		
chocolate labrador	truffle oil	cocoa tea		
chocolate fountain	truffle shuffle	cocoa bean		
chocolate labs	white truffles	hot cocoa mix		
chocolate booty	black truffles	hot cocoa recipe		
chocolate wedding favors	easy truffle recipes	cocoa tree		
history of chocolate	chocolate truffles recipe	cocoa powder		
↓ more	↓ more	↓ more		

Here's what your final matrix may look like:

chocolate →	truffles	cocoa	fudge	candy → more
hot chocolate	truffles	cocoa	fudge	candy
chocolate chip cookies	chocolate truffles	cocoa beach	fudge recipes	candy shop
charlie and the chocolate factory	truffle	hot cocoa	peanut butter fudge	candy samples
chocolate and dessert recipes	chocolate truffle recipe	cocoa beach florida	fudge recipe	best candy bars
chocolate chip cookie recipe	truffle recipes	hot cocoa mix recipe	peanut butter fudge recipe	candy canes
lg chocolate	chocolate truffle recipes	cocoa beans	pumpkin fudge	candy cane
chocolate cake	truffle recipe	cocoa puffs	easy fudge recipes	candy loving
chocolate phone	oreo truffles	cocoa butter	chocolate fudge	eye candy
chocolate labrador	truffle oil	cocoa tea	church of fudge	50 cent candy shop
chocolate fountain	truffle shuffle	cocoa bean	vanilla fudge	candy corn
chocolate labs	white truffles	hot cocoa mix	best fudge recipes	cotton candy
chocolate booty	black truffles	hot cocoa recipe	peanut butter fudge recipes	candy barr
chocolate wedding favors	easy truffle recipes	cocoa tree	fantasy fudge	hard candy
history of chocolate	chocolate truffles recipe	cocoa powder	chocolate fudge recipe	christmas candy recipes
↓ more	↓ more	↓ more	↓ more	↓ more

Final words

The average person will do their keyword research once and then forget about it. But that is the way to get average results.

Effective keyword research is an ongoing process and to get outstanding results you must work at it regularly.

To succed in keyword research you should:

1. Regularly check your keyword counts on Wordtracker - they can go up and down over time

2. Continue to add more keywords to your matrix. The more effective keywords you have, the more profitable your online business will be.

3. Monitor how well your keywords do. Performance will always be a mixture of:

   - Keywords that bring good traffic and good conversions (these are the words people use when they are in buying mode)

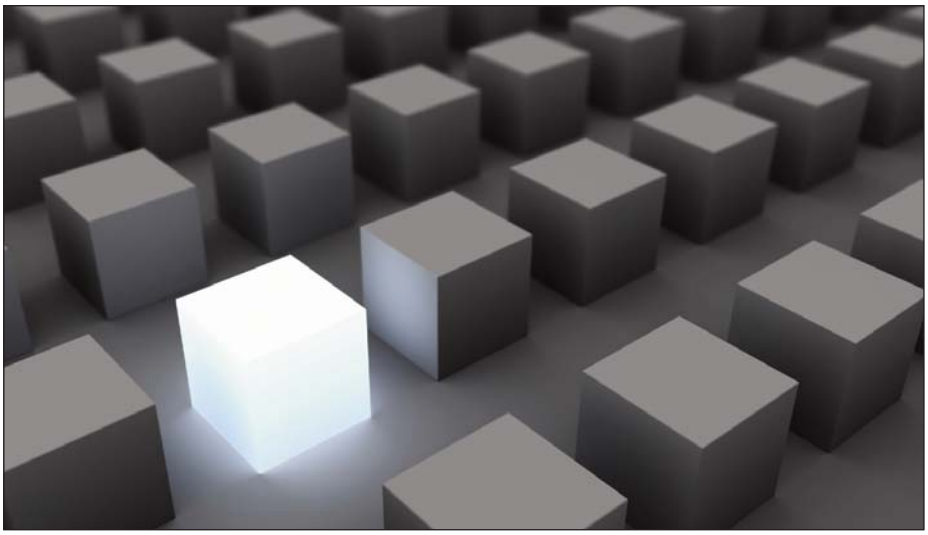
   - Keywords that bring you good traffic but poor conversions (these are the words people use when they are in research mode)

   - Keywords that bring low traffic but great conversions (these are the words that represent buying behaviour in niche markets).

Overall, there will be a mix of such keywords in any comprehensive keyword matrix.

In the next lesson, we'll look at how you can pick the most competitive keywords from the sample matrix that we have developed for 'chocolate' and how you can use those keywords in your web site copy.

Choosing your best keywords



So how do you choose the best keywords from the many that can be generated using Wordtracker. The next article in this series will look at how to use your best keywords to create high ranking pages.

In the previous lesson, **The Keyword Matrix**, we developed two spreadsheets for chocolate and related terms, one of 85 search terms using the free trial and one of over 5000 terms using the full version.

The spreadsheets gave a prediction of the **daily searches for each term**:

Keyword generated for 'chocolate'	Predict
chocolate	7925
hot chocolate	1497
chocolate chip cookies	1231
charlie and the chocolate factory	1135
chocolate and dessert recipes	1111
chocolate chip cookie recipe	1007
lg chocolate	830
chocolate cake	794
chocolate phone	741
chocolate labrador	735
chocolate fountain	677
chocolate labs	636
chocolate booty	631

The 'predict' figure is the first metric you should look at. High scoring keywords will be the most popular words in your marketplace - the words

people use when they're searching for your products - so 'gifts' for a luxury chocolate site, 'cheap flights' for a travel site.

But of course there is a problem. Because the keywords are so popular, lots of sites will use them. You will face a lot of competition and much of that competition will be good at search engine optimization.

An experienced SEO will welcome this challenge and will apply skill and hard work over a number of months to compete effectively. But a novice SEO will find it virtually impossible to compete for these highly popular keywords. What then should the novice do?

Strategies for a novice SEO

I think there are three strategies you should follow:

1. **Include the most popular keywords in your website copy,** even though you may not rank well for them. Your customers will expect to see these keywords, and search engines will take note of them. By including them, you lay a foundation for the long term: slowly but surely as you add more content, your rankings will rise.

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2. **Use the most popular keywords along with 'qualifiers'**, either geographic or sector specific. So while it might be difficult to rank well for 'chocolate gifts', it is not such a challenge to rank well for 'chocolate gifts Buffalo' targeting a geographic area or 'corporate chocolate gifts' targeting the business sector.

3. **Look for niche keywords or markets that others haven't yet found.** Such keywords have the magic combination of being relatively popular searches, but having little competition. Wordtracker provides a measurement for this - KEI or keyword effectiveness index. Many SEOs adopt this niche keyword strategy: John Alexander and Robin Nobles explain the approach in detail in this excellent article - **An Ingenious way to Use Wordtracker.**

Wordtracker provides you with a number of metrics to help in these strategies. You can see them here in the full version (similar metrics are available with the trial):

Your keyword list

select delete save

	Keyword	Searches	Predict	Google	Google KEI
1	chocolate	6,706	11,827	128,000,000	0.35
2	chocolate and dessert recipes	1,618	2,853	31,700	82.58
3	hot chocolate	1,371	2,417	2,070,000	0.91
4	chocolate chip cookies	989	1,744	1,380,000	0.71
5	charlie and the chocolate factory	912	1,608	1,690,000	0.49
6	chocolate chip cookie recipe	801	1,412	126,000	5.09
7	chocolate cake	689	1,215	1,660,000	0.29
8	chocolate phone	653	1,151	540,000	0.79
9	lg chocolate	629	1,109	2,010,000	0.20
10	chocolate labs	603	1,063	56,000	6.49
11	chocolate booty	542	955	20,400	14.40
12	chocolate lab	523	922	471,000	0.58

Here's what each of these terms mean:

- **Searches** is the number of times the exact keyword appears in our sample of people's searches.

- **Predict** is the number of times over a 24-hour period that we estimate the exact keyword will be searched for over all engines.

- **Google** is the number of results that Google will return for the exact search term in quotation marks (you can also choose other search engines).

- **Google KEI** (Keyword Effectiveness Index) is a calculation of the "effectiveness" of each keyword, taking into account the predicted searches and the number of competing pages.

So let's look at our three strategies again using Wordtracker metrics.

1. **Include the most popular keywords in your website copy.** This means including the keywords that have a high 'predict' figure into your keyword strategy.

2. **Use the most popular keywords along with 'qualifiers'.** Look at the Google competition figure. If this is too high, add a qualifier to the keyword. So, instead of optimizing for 'chocolate gifts', optimize for 'chocolate gifts Buffalo'.

3. **Look for niche keywords or markets that others haven't yet found.** Pay close attention to the Google KEI column. By clicking on 'Google KEI' at the top of the table, Wordtracker will sort your entire list in descending order of KEI.

As with all things in search engine optimization you have to use a mixture

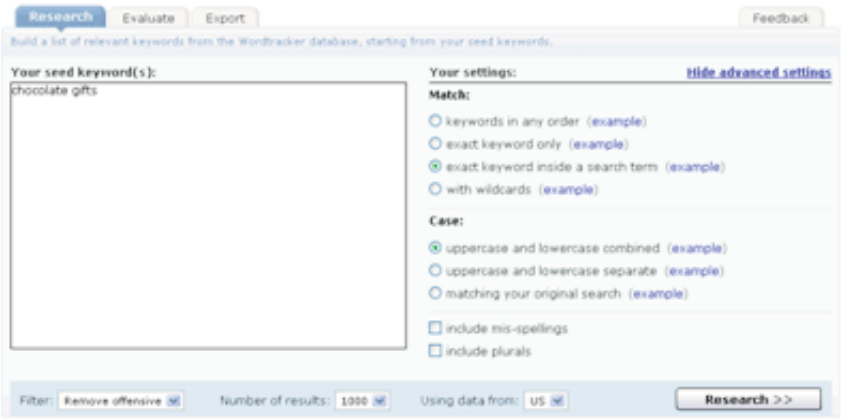
of solid data AND human intelligence. Keyword research is not a simple one-off task. You will achieve much more if you investigate the tools, think about what they tell you about people, and develop your own ideas and methodologies.

A final tip to expand your keyword list

If you optimize well for a phrase such as “chocolate gifts”, you may also pick up traffic from people who are doing the longer search ‘corporate chocolate gifts’. So having an idea of these longer phrases can help you estimate your overall market.

Wordtracker reports on exact search terms only, so keywords such as “corporate chocolate gifts” do not influence the count for “chocolate gifts”.

To find these additional keywords do this search in the full version of Wordtracker: Keyword Researcher tool.



Your keyword list

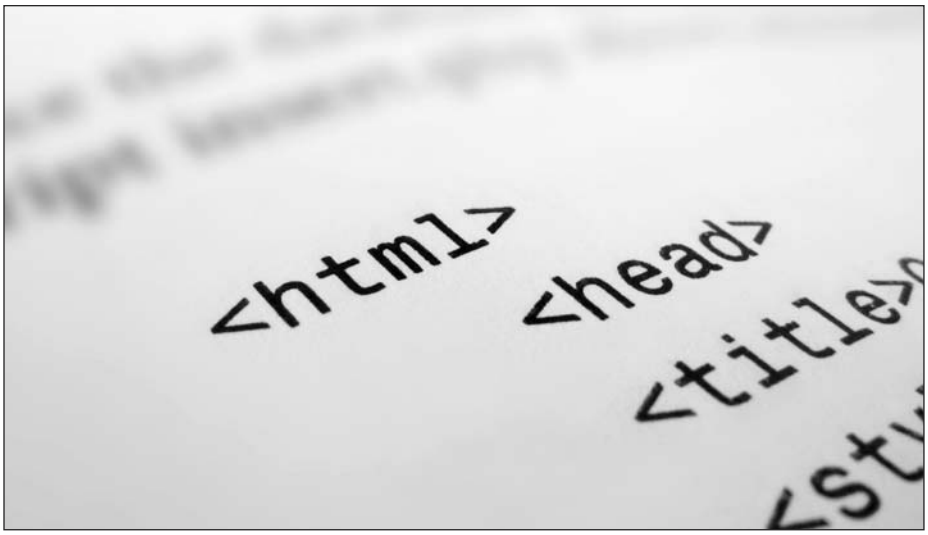
select delete save

	Keyword	Searches	Predict
1	chocolate gifts	109	192
2	custom chocolate gifts	12	21
3	corporate chocolate gifts	12	21
4	hershey chocolate gifts	9	15
5	unique chocolate gifts	8	14
6	novelty chocolate gifts	7	12
7	gourmet chocolate gifts	7	12

The results will show a prediction of 386 for phrases that contain ‘chocolate gifts’ - almost twice as many as for ‘chocolate gifts’ alone.

Now you'll have gathered and prioritized many relevant keywords. In lesson 4, we'll explore how you can use these keywords in your website copywriting so that you attract much more of the traffic you want.

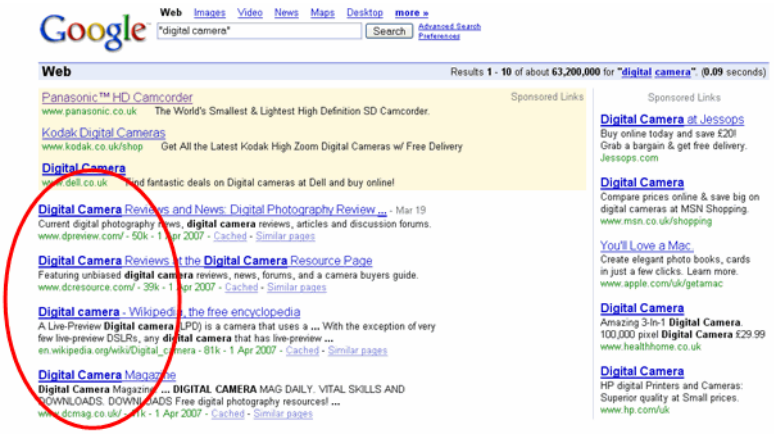
Using keywords in website copywriting



So you've done all your keyword research and you've found the best keywords for your website. How do you use these keywords to improve your website copywriting so that you rank well on the search engines and attract the type of customers that you are after?

Example of good website copywriting

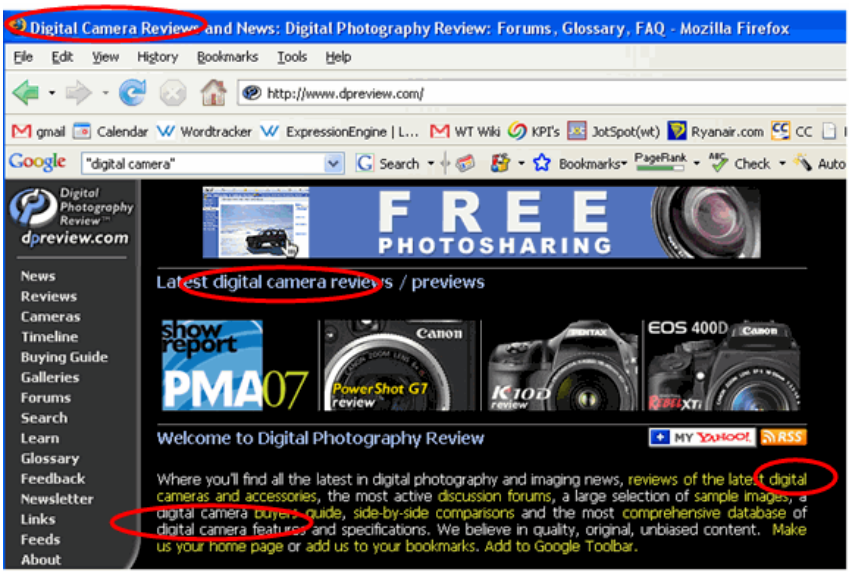
Well, let's start with an example of a well-written and highly ranked website in a competitive sector – digital cameras. I'll go to Google and do a search, say for "digital camera": at the time of writing, here are the results:



See how the titles of the top organic searches all include the search term 'digital camera'. The words that appear in the title are completely within your control: the title tag is the most important place to put your primary keyword.

So the top organic result comes from www.dpreview.com who have succeeded against 63 million competing pages – a great performance. So what can we learn by following the link?

Let's have a look:

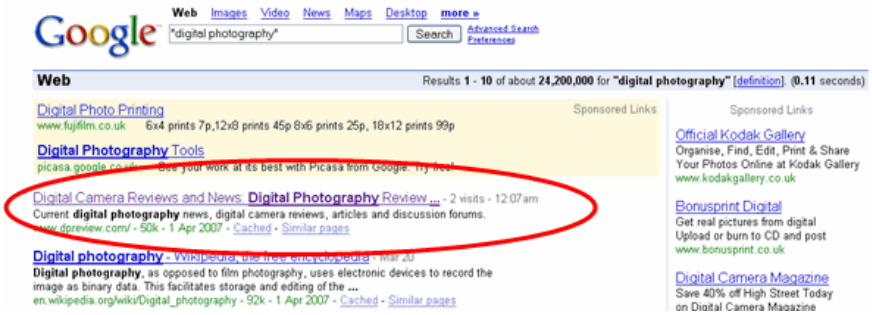


Look at how the keyword 'digital camera' has been used in the title, the heading, linking text and the body copy.

This is a well optimized page. But have a closer look at the title in the next diagram – it contains another important keyword, 'digital photography'.

This keyword is also used well in the website copy:
So how does this page perform for the search 'digital photography'?
Does the page rank as well as it did for 'digital camera'?

Here are the results from Google:



Top again with over 24 million competing web pages. A very nice piece of work and one you should try to emulate. The person writing this copy really knew what they were doing.

Using keywords in your web copy

Here are the steps I'll go through to create a piece of optimized web copy.

1. From the keyword lists you have chosen for your site, pick a primary and a secondary keyword that you'll want to rank well for with the article.

2. Write the title of the article making sure that you include the primary keyword in the title. You can also try to fit in the secondary phrase but if you find it hard to do so and still maintain good English, then don't worry about the secondary keyword in your title. I try and keep the title to around 50 characters in length.

3. Write the description tag using both the primary and secondary keywords. This should describe what the article is about and should be around 200-250 characters long.

4. Write the first paragraph which should be a summary of the overall article and should include both primary and secondary keywords. If you're not sure about how to do this, have a look at my first paragraph here or study good newspaper writing. You'll find that journalists tend to summarize the story in the very first paragraph.

Get writing, get publishing, measure what happens – and then do it even better next time.

5. Next, map out the structure of the article, writing headings and subheading that each contain keywords. Not only does this help you write good search engine copy, but it focuses your mind on what you really want to say and the quality of your writing will improve. In this article, for example, here's the structure I've followed:

   - Using keywords in website copywriting
   - Example of good website copywriting
   - Using keywords in your web copy – 6 steps
   - Improving your website copywriting skills
   - Internal and external resources to link to.

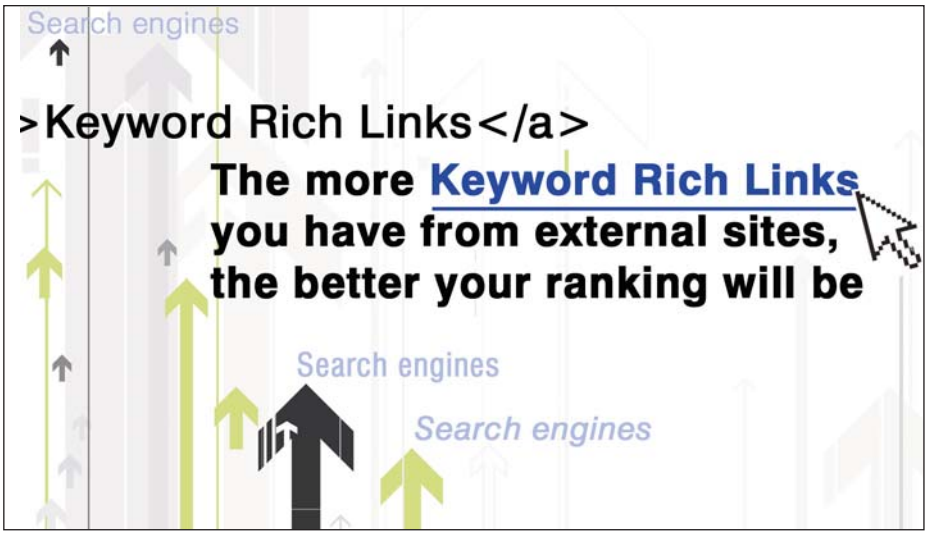
6. Finally, think about the internal and external links that you might point people to. The linking text should be keyword rich.

Improving your website copywriting skills

This lesson has given you some tips and a step-by-step process to follow. However, you'll get nowhere unless you put some of this advice into action and then see what happens to your search engine traffic. Then build on what works and discard what doesn't.

My favorite definition of an expert is "someone who has made more mistakes than anyone else". So don't be afraid – get writing, get publishing, measure what happens – and then do it even better next time.

Build Keyword Rich Inbound Links



if you can persuade external sites to link to you using keyword rich linking text then you'll get a significant search engine boost.

To rank well in search engine results you need to score well on both 'on the page' and 'off the page' factors. On the page factors are about what is on your own pages and therefore within your own control: off the page factors are the links from external websites to your own and these are much more difficult to control.

Most external links will use your domain to link to you, but if you can persuade them to link to you using keyword rich linking text (sometimes called anchor text), then you'll get a significant search engine boost.

So while AbeBooks.com would be pleased with a link like http://www.abebooks.com, they would be even more pleased with a link like used books from AbeBooks because the linking text contains one of their important keywords, 'used books'.

For many website managers and owners getting an external link of any kind is achievement enough, without having to manage the even more difficult task of persuading an external website to link to you using specific keyword phrases of your choice.

So how do you get keyword rich inbound links?

In an earlier section, we showed you how to choose product and publication names to get such links: and there are other methods that if you persist will bring you many valuable links.

But before we list them, you need to do some preparation:

- Start by choosing 5-10 of your most popular keywords that you're going to use in your initial link building campaign.

- Now write variations of the links that you'd like to use. For example to create the link used books from AdeBooks, I'd write the following html:

<a href="http://www.adebooks.com/">used books from AdeBooks</a>

You'll want to create a variety of inbound links using different variations of linking text.

There are simple steps you can take to start getting keyword rich links. They include:

(i) Simply show people how you'd like them to link to you. Write the html, make it available and ask people just to copy and paste the code into their own web pages.

(ii) Buy directory links or text ad that allow you to specify the linking text.

(iii) Build contacts and relationships within your industry. Be generous in linking to useful external resources and you'll find that the people you link to take notice and your generosity will often be rewarded with links back to your own site. If you've built a good relationship, people will be glad to use the linking text you suggest.

(iv) Write newsworthy press releases and use services such as www.prweb.com to distribute them. For a small additional fee they will allow you to embed links into the body of your press release.

(v) Write and publish quality articles and blog posts on your own site. Make sure that you include important keywords in the titles of each article or post. People will generally use those titles when they link to you.

(vi) Quality news and information sites in your industry will often accept well-written articles for publication. When they do, they'll normally publish a signature box describing what you do and linking to your site in whatever way you specify.

We hope you've enjoyed your Keywords Basics course. You can learn even more from the articles, case studies and tips we publish at the Wordtracker Academy. And make sure you sign up for the Keyword Expert Newsletter so that you get vital information before your competitors.